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Political tensions between India and Canada have also impacted Indian student admissions to Canadian universities. Indian students who may have opted to apply to Canadian universities and B-schools like McGill, are opting to study in India because of the political tensions between India and Canada.

One estimate by an education consultant, who did not wish to be named, suggests that student applications from India to Canada are at a five-year low.

They also believe that while better-known Canadian institutes like University of British Columbia and University of Toronto will still be attractive to

Indian students, admissions to the smaller and lesser-known business schools will be affected.

A two-year post graduate Programme (PGP) at Indian Institute of Management-Ahmedabad costs about ₹27 lakh, while a one-year MBA at Indian School of Business (ISB) costs ₹42 lakh. Most of the schools have finished the interview rounds of shortlisted candidates and would announce the selected candidates over the next few weeks.

Some like the Great Lakes Institute of Management in Chennai and in the National Capital Region have already announced their admitted students, possibly hoping to close in on the better candidates before the top schools like the IIMs of Ahmedabad, Bangalore

and Calcutta announce their successful candidates. An MBA degree from overseas universities would be more expensive than one obtained from Indian universities. To address that, foreign universities like the University of Southampton and Australia's Deakin University are setting up campuses in India at Gurgaon and GIFT city, Gujarat respectively. It would be cheaper for students in India to study in these institutions within the country.

"Indian students and their parents are very aspirational, but at the same time, they are gradually becoming cost-conscious too about the return on their investment with increased employability options. Foreign higher education institutions which want to

DIGITAL SKILLS LIKE AI, BLOCKCHAIN, GAMING, AND DATA ANALYTICS HAVE BEEN ADDED TO THE CURRICULUM

establish their campuses in India will need to perhaps revise their pedagogy to suit the academic needs of the aspirational Indian students," says Snigdha Moitra, Senior Advisor, Prospectus International, which provides foreign universities with insights on how to develop academic opportunities in India and South Asia, and former admissions consultant to ISB.

An encouraging trend this year has been Indian B-schools admitting larger number of female students. ISB—which has traditionally focussed on representation of women candidates—is further strengthening its diversity quotient this year. For example, the male to female admissions ratio is almost equal at 50%. Several newer IIMs have also reserved

seats for women. IMT Ghaziabad has introduced a 25% tuition fee waiver in the form of a scholarship for every female student, this year. This is quite different from the model that is in place in IIM-Kozhikode, where additional points are given to female students in the admission process.

The choice of courses, specialisations and curriculum needs within an MBA programme have changed a lot this year. Digital skills like artificial intelligence (AI), blockchain, gaming and data analytics have been added to the curriculum. "What most good business schools are doing is to add courses related to data analytics and AI into the general management MBA programme.

Further, the institution invests in the latest software and tools related to these domains so that students are industry ready. At IMT, we are doing this," Harvinder Singh of IMT, Ghaziabad, says.

A recent report from Careers360, a management education portal, says that students are also opting to specialise

in certain sunrise sectors like healthcare, sustainability, social impact and sports management. In business schools that take this approach, the first year would be a common general management course, while the second year would focus on an industry or sector.

The latest specialisations focused on technology is different from the traditional functional specialisations like human resources and finance. Entrepreneurship is another interest area among students.

In this global era of start-ups, it is an estimated 50% of the MBA graduates from Harvard Business School typically go on to create robust entrepreneurial ventures after their studies. India is moving in the same direction. **BT**